What am I? – A Collection

By Leah Anderson, Timothy D. Prott and Laura Hymson

You Ask Me What I am So you May Know How to Fear Me by Leah Anderson

I see you from across the room with your question mark
brows,
arms crossed in expectation,
head on tilt.
Watch you come slinking towards me,
and before we've even met, before you've even asked my
name,
before you've even said, "Hello, what a fine day we're
having,"
you stare at my face like a map you cannot read,
like a puzzle with centerpiece missing,
like a game you will play and will win.
"Your eyes," you say - and here comes the grocery store
list.

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"Almonds," you say, "with a spoonful of mint jelly."
"Honey," you say, "with the zest of a lime.
The inside of a Tootsie Pop mixed with green apple Pop
Rocks.

What are you?"

INTRODUCTION

What are you?! It's a question that people of mixed ethnicity endure with far too much frequency, one that is asked, quite often, with no regard for culture or background, simply as a way to classify a person. We might not realize the pain it causes to be asked this, but our ignorance does not excuse our callousness.

*We must always be interested in a person's story, not as a means of filing them into a box, but as a way to celebrate their uniqueness and individualism. If we want to to know **"who"** a person is, we have to learn how to listen and how to ask questions that honor their answers.*

What am I?- A Collection including "You Ask Me What I am So you May Know How to Fear Me" by Leah Anderson; "Fitting In" by Timothy D. Prott; and "What am I?" by Laura Hymson

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What are you?"

Words so familiar yet sharp,
like the pain in the side after running a mile on a full stomach,
like an old pocket knife, handle worn smooth in your hand
but still dried in blood after all these years.
"Well . . . " I say, but already you are gone,
turned on your heels, retreating to safe spaces.
This is not what you wanted.
You want a one-word answer. But friend, this is not a one-word story.
There is a child whose ancestors came from across a salty blue sea.
She is one half of the world's population.
She is multiplying by the second.
She is unstoppable, yet on this soil she is taught to be silent,
to never raise her hand, never make too much trouble,
never make herself known.
They fear her for the magic she holds between her ears,

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for the magic of momentum that will not be still.

There is a child whose ancestors have always lived here.
They crossed borders that were created
only out of some colorless man's imagination,
yet within these lines, she is told she does not belong,
to go back where she came from,
as if where she came from is not where she is,
as if her limbs were not birthed on this land,
as if her toes have not always known the feel of this earth.
They fear her for the magic she holds in soft places,
for the magic of her seeds spreading like wildflowers in the spring.

There is a child whose ancestors came on ships.
They were kings in a land we all came from,
before we even knew what white was,
before we set it on an altar, apart and above.
Yet here she is told that her scars are too loud,
that she must hide all evidence of building a country on

her back,
that she must be content
that things now are better than they have been,
though every breath and bullet would tell her differently.
They fear her for the magic she holds in the bones of her memory,
for the magic of her song that will not lay down quietly.
You ask me what I am and hear my words as mutiny,
igniting fires you are not ready for in your comfortable home,
surrounded by your books and your friends,
not even noticing when you look around the room
that your skin is all the milky same,
that you have learned how to keep out anything
that may dirty the walls of your castles,
that may challenge the sovereignty of your thrones.

And where does this fear come from?
We all run when we're scared, or turn with fists up and fight,

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or drop to the ground to find solace in the earth,
or find some sense in the smell of the grass.

I can tell you my history in terms of trauma,
or laughter, or scars on my knees, or books on my shelves,
or the number of times my heart has been broken.
I can tell you my history by the things my eyes have seen,
but you learn nothing by the shape of them.

You ask me what I am and search for safety in the answer.
There is no safety here.
There is a child whose ancestors came from opposite ends of the earth.
They met in the middle in a land where the air is sticky and sweet.
She loves Malay and eating ice cream in bed,
and the way her body feels when covered in mud and in sweat

and small living things she can hold in the palm of her hand.

She is too young for stillness.

She is too old for silence.

And her eyes . . .

her eyes change color with the wind.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Leah Anderson
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Fitting In by Timothy D. Prott

Why won't I fit in?

Is it the way I dress?

I dress the only way I know how.

I dress to feel comfortable, not to impress.

It is no more justified to judge a person on their style

Than it is to judge them on their lack thereof.

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It is like judging how a walnut will taste

By examining the bumps and ridges on its shell.

The two entities, though one unit, are not directly related to one

another.

I dress the only way I know how.

Perhaps it is how I talk

I speak the way my parents taught me.

My speech is for clarification, not for impression.

Why is it that one group denotes my speech as "too proper,"

Whereas another group sees it as "not proper enough?"

If I wanna be down, I have to speak a certain way.

If I wanna rise up, I have to speak a certain way.

Or so they say . . .

You know what I say?

I say my voice is my character.

To know my speech is to know me.

I don't think anyone sees it my way.

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I wonder if it is the way I carry myself.
My personality is not one that stands out.
Except to those who are in my soul.
Low-key, you might say, is the word for me.
At least that is what you see
Unless I let you in.
But for some this is my drawback
They use my personality as a means to discredit me.
Telling me I'm this or that
Placing me in a category because of my choice.

Can't they see!
If you strip away all the matter we are all the same.
But they will never see me as such.
So they use my personality as a crutch.
To justify their false beliefs in facts they themselves
    cannot prove.
Is that what we have come to?

Or is it the one defining factor that our society
    choosed [sic] to use
To separate us?

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Is it my race that keeps me from the fit?
For me the answer is two sided, you see
Yet joined in one, in its simplicity
I'll admit, "race" has been a benefit and a burden.
But what is so important about this four-letter word?

For some it is the ladder upon which they climb.
For others it is the heavy chain that chokes the very
life from them
For the vast majority, it is very significant.
It is the reason the square does not fit with the round
And the triangular does not fit with the trapezoidal
It separates us like oil separates from water.

What does race mean to me?
One who straddles the boundaries between night and
    day?
Race is just a word.
Simply a word.
Not a barrier to be crossed
Not an obstacle to be overcome

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Not a crutch upon which I support my very existence.

A word.

And once they see as I see

With the pureness of their hearts

Not with their eyes

Then and then will I truly fit in.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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What am I? by Laura Hymson

What am I?

You want a one-word answer. But friend, this is not a one-word story. (from Poem #1)

I was born out of love

Fostered in confusion

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Came to stumble on pride and inner strength

Found power within myself

I never knew what I was but I knew what I was not

I knew then I did not fit into one of your small boxes of identity

I know now I am too big, too strong to curl up into one of your conventional

convenient categories of existence

I knew then I was different, special, unique

I know now just how special I am

I am the small minded man's fear

The fear of the unknown

The nameless

The outsider

What am I?

Each one of our answers lies out there somewhere before us

Our identities waiting to be claimed

Claimed, not by a checked off box nor society nor anyone else other than you,

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the individual, the perfect combination, the union of two

beautiful

cultures, backgrounds, and colors

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